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Peizhi Huang & Hongcheng Lu

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Digital feminist humor as a weapon: a humor and topic analysis of the weibo posts of the fat cat event

Peizhi Huang  and Hongcheng Lu 

School of Journalism and Communication, Tsinghua University, China

ABSTRACT

This article investigates how digital feminist humor intervened in the gendered politics of the 2024 “Fat Cat” incident on Weibo. It examines how a seemingly neutral mourning ritual for a male gamer became a contested arena of platformed misogyny and feminist resistance, where sympathy, blame, and moral authority were negotiated in China’s digital sphere. Using a mixed-methods design that combines automated humor recognition and topic modeling of 5537 posts with critical discourse analysis, we trace how female users mobilized irony, parody, and satire to defamiliarize the memorial and challenge dominant manosphere framings. The findings show that humor operated as a strategic mode of platformed activism. It enabled affective solidarity and condensed structural critique into replicable meme templates that could circulate across topics and moments. By situating this case within feminist humor scholarship, the article conceptualizes digital humor as a political resource for navigating constrained media environments and for reworking gendered counterpublics online.

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Introduction

On April 11 2024, a Chinese game trainer nicknamed “Fat Cat” tragically jumped off the Yangtze River Bridge in Chongqing. Following his death, his sister selectively released chat logs and transaction records, framing his suicide as the outcome of emotional manipulation by his girlfriend, Tan. This narrative triggered a wave of public indignation. As Fat Cat was rumored to have lived frugally while transferring money to Tan, mourning practices took a platform-specific form. Users began ordering food deliveries, primarily milk tea and fast food, to be left on the bridge. Rapidly amplified on social media, this ritual transformed the bridge into an ephemeral digital shrine.

However, this seemingly neutral memorial quickly acquired a distinctly gendered dimension. Many users, particularly women, challenged the idealized portrayal of Fat Cat by producing satirical “food-delivery” dark humor and memes. Rather than treating this as a straightforward “shift in opinion,” we approach it as a struggle over frames, including who deserves sympathy, who deserves blame, and whose moral judgment carries authority. The widespread debate was followed by an official investigation. On

May 19 2024, the Chongqing police stated that Fat Cat and Tan had mutual financial transactions and that the circulation of selectively released materials had contributed to online harassment directed at Tan. The disclosure did not resolve the conflict; instead, it sharpened existing divisions and extended the debate about intimacy, obligation, and gendered expectations online.

The humor generated by female users proved critical to this evolving discourse, underscoring the power of digital feminist humor in sustaining counter-readings and keeping alternative framings visible. This case parallels prominent Western examples of digital feminist humor, such as “This Pussy Grabs Back” (Inger-Lise K Bore, Anne Graefer and Allaina Kilby 2017) and the “Binders Full of Women” meme (Carrie A Rentschler and Samantha C Thrift 2015), where humor functions as a tool of feminist activism by subverting dominant narratives and making structural inequalities legible (Cynthia Willett, Julie Willett and Yael D Sherman 2012).

Considering the specificity of China’s platform environment, this study asks how the food-delivery memorial ritual became a site for feminist humor and gendered contestation. We examine how a seemingly neutral online ritual was repurposed by female users as a form of boundary work and critique, and we analyze what this case reveals about digital feminist humor as a political resource under conditions where explicit feminist speech can be costly.

The paper proceeds in three steps. First, we contextualize China’s platform environment and explain why the Fat Cat incident became a flashpoint for gender politics. Next, we clarify key debates in feminist humor scholarship and set out the criteria we use to distinguish feminist humor from merely gendered ridicule, focusing on the target and direction of the punchline. Finally, the empirical analysis combines NLP-based humor recognition, topic modeling, and close reading to trace discursive shifts around the food-delivery ritual and to show how humorous frames circulated as the narrative evolved.

Misogyny and Manosphere in China

In response to the rising feminist agendas online, traditional hegemonic masculinity has reacted with the emergence of emotional “misogyny” encompassing anti-feminist rhetoric, misogynistic ideology, and elements of male separatism (Sarah Banet-Weiser 2018; Xiaoting Han and Chenjun Yin 2022). The term “Manosphere” was subsequently coined to describe these fragmented digital communities promoting misogynistic discourses, characterized by a critique of feminism and victimhood narratives. Various groups, including Men’s Rights Activists (MRAs), argue that feminists utilize “political correctness” to suppress men, resulting in “over-feminism”—a perceived sexist overreaction that men feel compelled to counter (Alice E Marwick and Robyn Caplan 2018; Marwick and Rebecca Lewis 2017; Mae Shaw and Marjorie Mayo 2016). Viewing women’s growing influence as excessive, the Manosphere frequently instigates cyberabuse and cyberhate directed at women both online and offline (Emma A Jane 2017; Shawn P Van Valkenburgh 2019). Scholars have conceptualized the Manosphere as a discursive movement within feminist social micropolitics that reproduces itself in digital spaces, framing women’s online presence as an incursion into previously male-dominated cyberspace (Jane 2017; Adam Kendel 2020; M Lilly 2016; Ann-Kathrin Rothermel 2022; Robert M Schmitz and Emily Kazyak 2016).

In China, these global trends intertwine with unique national characteristics (S Liao 2024). Chinese feminism continues to confront deeply rooted traditional gender roles and a patriarchal culture heavily influenced by Confucian ethics (Xin Chen and Lijun Zheng 2023). Because offline feminist movements are frequently subject to censorship, social media platforms have become essential spaces for Chinese feminists to share experiences, organize protests, and challenge conventional gender norms (Chen and Zheng 2023; Qian Huang 2023). However, this increased visibility attracts significant hostility, exacerbating acute online misogyny within the Chinese digital landscape (Chen and Zheng 2023).

Consequently, a distinct Chinese “Manosphere” has emerged, adapting global reactionary discourses to the local context (Han and Yin 2022). Unlike global counterparts operating in more decentralized spaces (Krendel 2020), the Chinese Manosphere is significantly shaped by the “platformization of misogyny” within a state-market nexus (Liao 2024). Platforms like Weibo are not neutral; their design features and algorithms actively amplify misogyny (Ling Han and Yue Liu 2024). Combined with state control and commercial polarization, this environment provides fertile ground for anti-feminist narratives. Furthermore, these misogynistic sentiments are often rooted in traditional cultural narratives. For instance, Chen and Zheng (2023) note that Chinese misogyny upholds Confucian patriarchal traditions and rigid gender roles, frequently criticizing women for deviating from these norms or for perceived “materialism.” Thus, the Chinese Manosphere appears more mainstream, acute, and aggressive than its global counterparts. In this context, social media discourse plays a pivotal yet paradoxical role in contemporary Chinese feminist activism. While essential for expression and organization under regulation, it simultaneously fosters counter-feminist narratives. The “Fat Cat incident” exemplifies this complex dynamic, where women’s humor surrounding “food delivery” demonstrated significant socio-political potential by catalyzing societal reflection on male privilege. Understanding how such discursive power is mobilized is crucial for advancing digital feminism. This study employs the concept of “feminist humor” as a vital analytical lens to investigate this phenomenon.

Feminist humor in the digital age

As a sociocultural phenomenon, humor has long served as a tool for challenging power structures and stereotypes (Charles E Case and Cameron D Lippard 2009). While traditional frameworks—such as superiority, relief, and incongruity theories—provide a foundation for understanding its mechanisms, they often overlook the critical dimension of gender (J. G Lu 2023). Historically, humor has frequently been deployed to reinforce patriarchal structures, while women have simultaneously been stereotyped as lacking a creative sense of humor (Case and Lippard 2009). In contrast, feminist humor explicitly centers on gendered power relations. It aims to “expose and ridicule the absurdity of gender stereotypes and the inequalities behind them” (Joanne Gallivan 1992, 373) and to “make accustomed assumptions visible, and their stereotypical distortions laughable” (Zara Zimbardo 2014, 60). Crucially, feminist humor is distinguished from merely “gendered” humor by its political intent; rather than simply targeting individuals based on sex, it critiques the underlying structures of patriarchal dominance (Mary Crawford 2003). It functions as both an emotional outlet and a political instrument used to dismantle

normative gender roles and reconstruct female identity (Limor Shifman and Dafna Lemish 2010).

In this article, we treat “feminist” humor as an analytic category rather than a demographic one. A joke is not feminist simply because it is produced by women, nor is it feminist merely because it targets men. Instead, we identify feminist humor by where its comic force lands. Across the corpus, three cues are especially salient. First, the target of ridicule is structural: patriarchal norms, misogynistic common sense, or the gendered moral economy that allocates credibility and sympathy unevenly, rather than essentialized traits of “men” or “women.” Second, the stance it invites is recognitional rather than scapegoating: it draws attention to contradictions, double standards, or moral posturing that sustains gender hierarchy. Third, its punchline “punches up” by destabilizing dominant frames and making taken-for-granted assumptions laughable, even when the style is abrasive or dark. These cues allow us to distinguish feminist humor from merely gendered ridicule and from postfeminist play that weakens structural critique (Crawford 2003; Shifman and Lemish 2010).

To clarify its specific function, it is essential to distinguish it from other categories. Shifman and Lemish (2010) identify three key types: sexist, feminist, and postfeminist humor. Sexist humor reinforces gender hierarchies, often through objectification and negative stereotypes (Memo Bergmann 1986). In contrast, feminist humor actively critiques patriarchal structures, challenges traditional gender roles, and fosters empowerment by mocking dominant masculinities and systemic inequalities (Crawford 2003).

Postfeminist humor, conversely, is more ambiguous. It frequently emphasizes “essential differences” between genders while reframing consumerism and individual choice as empowerment. Scholars debate whether postfeminism extends feminist thought or represents a “backlash” that erodes earlier gains (Rachel Moseley and Jacinda Read 2002). A key limitation is its tendency to weaken structural critique. By centering biological difference and consumer-based “empowerment,” postfeminist humor risks devolving into depoliticized “lifestyle feminism” (Mary Douglas Vavrus 2002) that reinforces rather than challenges patriarchal structures (Limor Shifman and Dafna Lemish 2011). Digital media has transformed these practices into a distinct genre of digital feminist humor (Kirsti Cole 2018; Rentschler and Thrift 2015). Social media platforms, along with content-sharing mechanisms like hashtags and memes, have provided crucial safe spaces for creative expression. Tumblr, for instance, became a significant incubator for feminist humor due to its anonymity and supportive community atmosphere, which allows women to feel safer when challenging misogyny and harassment (Rentschler and Thrift 2015; Jessica Ringrose and Emma Lawrence 2018). Digital feminist humor often employs memes as a medium, seamlessly integrating images, text, and pop culture for rapid dissemination and shared impact. Notable examples include the “Binders Full of Women” meme (Rentschler and Thrift 2015) and Laura Vitis and Fairleigh Gilmour’s (2017) analysis of the “Instagranniepants” project. This humor utilizes diverse strategies, such as ironic reappropriation (e.g., the “Misandry Mermaid” account which satirizes the accusations of male rights activists), embodied challenge (humorously exposing privileged male behaviors like “manspreading”), and the subversive gaze (e.g., the “critiquemydickpic” Tumblr account, which deconstructs the threatening intent of unsolicited explicit photos) (Rentschler and Thrift 2015; Lawrence and Ringrose 2018). These strategies

leverage humor's affective power—including anger, joy, and solidarity—to foster community, challenge entrenched societal norms, and forge new “counterpublics.”

Despite its subversive potential, digital feminist humor encounters contextual limitations that can lead to significant misinterpretation. For instance, feminist humor that resonates in Chinese live performance may provoke backlash when disseminated online (K Kein 2015; Rosie White 2013). Digital spaces also enable the mobilization of reclaimed slurs and dark humor, elements that frequently blur the lines between constructive critique and malicious trolling (Adrienne L Massanari 2019). Furthermore, this style of humor is sometimes perceived as overly “heavy” or disproportionately reliant on “dark humor,” potentially limiting its broader appeal and complicating its reception. The “Fat Cat” incident in China offers a critical case study: while satirical “food delivery” memes were crucial in challenging an idealized male victim narrative, the extent to which such confrontational tactics genuinely advance feminist activism requires further empirical verification. Therefore, this study aims to examine how the Fat Cat Incident, which did not initially arise as a gender-related issue, evolved into a “gender war.” This study utilizes the case to reveal the pervasive misogynistic environment in Chinese cyberspace and to illuminate how women have deployed digital feminist humor as a form of resistance. This context leads to the following research questions:

RQ1: How did women utilize digital feminist humor within the discourse surrounding the “Fat Cat incident,” and what was the connection between this humor and the “food delivery” ritual?

RQ2: In what ways did this digital feminist humor challenge dominant narratives and reshape the gendered discourse of the “Fat Cat incident” on Chinese social media?

Method

To comprehensively depict the dynamics of gender politics in Chinese cyberspace, we conduct NLP (Natural Language Processing) on the food-related posts during the Fat Cat event on Weibo. NLP enables scalable, systematic analysis of rapidly evolving social media discussions, complementing qualitative content and discourse analysis when the dataset is large and time-sensitive.

Computational outputs do not, on their own, tell us what humor does politically or how audiences receive it. We therefore use NLP as a mapping device and interpret the patterns through close reading. For each topic, we examine posts with high topic probabilities and high engagement to clarify how a joke works, what it targets, and how it travels. We also treat humor classification and gender labels as fallible signals rather than ground truth. Our analysis does not infer persuasion, attitude change, or offline impact from post volumes. Instead, it traces discursive trajectories and the shifting availability of frames over time. This mixed approach allows us to stay attentive to meaning-making while still capturing large-scale changes in participation and thematic emphasis.

Data collection and preprocessing

We selected Weibo as the primary data source due to its balanced gender ratio and its central role in Chinese gender-related discussions (Qiong Wang and Huhua Ouyang 2023; Yihong Yuan, Guixing Wei and Yongmei Lu 2018). Our dataset was collected during the peak discussion period (May 1–25, 2024) using a two-stage keyword selection process based on high-frequency terms related to the food-delivery ritual (Table 1).

The final dataset comprises 5537 posts. Since Weibo requires users to report gender, we categorized 1316 posts from male users and 4420 from female users. As illustrated in Figure 1, discussions peaked initially before May 6 and again around May 19 following the police report. Female users posted more frequently throughout the event, particularly during the initial narrative formation (May 2–12), suggesting higher participation levels in this dataset. Preprocessing involved removing noisy elements (emojis, duplicates), Chinese word segmentation via jieba, and stop-word removal.

Analysis techniques

This research employs two prominent NLP techniques: humor recognition and topic modeling.

Table 1. Selected keywords for data collection.

Keywords	Translation	Frequency
外卖	Online food deliveries	1637
麦当劳	McDonald's	1500
奶茶	Bubble Tea	640
华莱士	Wallace ¹	553
茶百道	Cha Ba Dao ²	522
蜜雪冰城	Mixue Bingcheng ³	165
肯德基	KFC	106

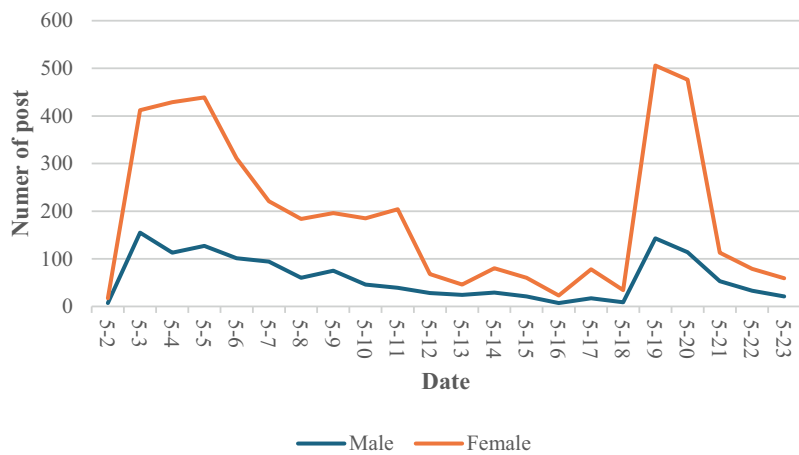


Figure 1. The trend of daily posts for different genders.

Humor recognition

Identifying humorous content has evolved from feature engineering (Rada Mihalcea and Carlo Strapparava 2006) to advanced pre-trained language models (G Kumari, D Bandyopadhyay, A Ekbal, S Pal, A Chatterjee and V. B N 2024; Siqi Xiong, Rongbo Wang, Xiaoxi Huang and Zhiqun Chen 2022). We employed CFunModel, a specialized Chinese humor-recognition model built on Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct and fine-tuned on the 160,000-sample CFunSet dataset (Zhenghan Yu, Xinyu Hu and Xiaojun Wan 2025). Each post was classified as “Humorous” or “Not Humorous” based on its use of irony, exaggeration, or unexpected logic through a standardized prompt.

Topic Modeling. We applied Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) to identify thematic structures (David M Blei, Andrew Y Ng, Michael I Jordan et al. 2003). Based on perplexity scores, we determined k = 20 topics as the optimal fit (Figure 2). Two coders manually labeled these topics based on top keywords and representative posts, achieving a high inter-coder reliability (Cohen’s Kappa = 0.85). This dual-methodological approach allows us to map both the frequency and the thematic focus of humorous dissent during the event.

Result

Humor recognition

As illustrated in Figure 3, the daily volume of humorous posts (May 1–25, 2024) displays two clear peaks—one in early May following the sister’s initial disclosures, and another on May 19, when the police report reframed the case.

Across the period, female users consistently produced more humorous posts than male users, and this gap persisted during the contested phase (May 7–18), when overall humorous output declined. Women’s humor production was also less volatile, with intermittent upticks that suggest a more sustained engagement as the narrative evolved. The May 19 report prompted a short-lived surge for both genders (women: 506; men: 143), followed by a gradual tapering. Taken together,

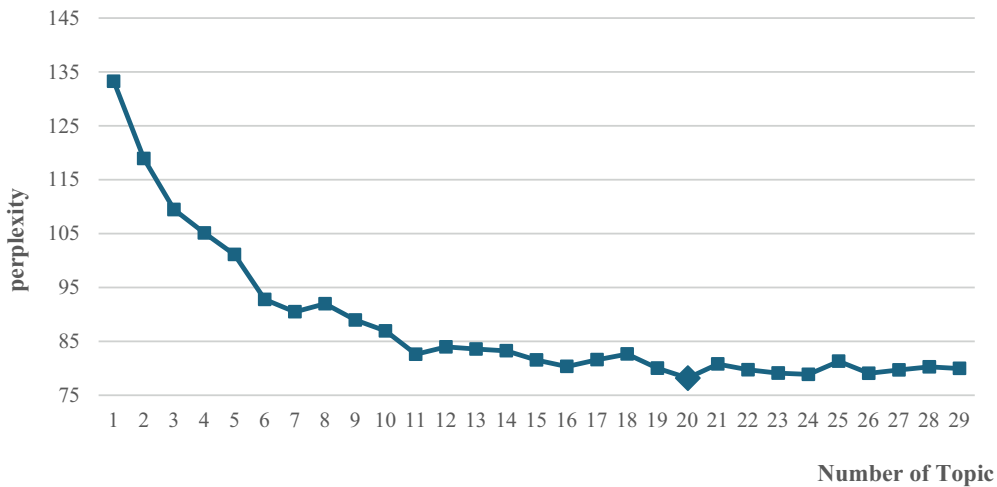


Figure 2. The perplexity curve of optimal Topic number.

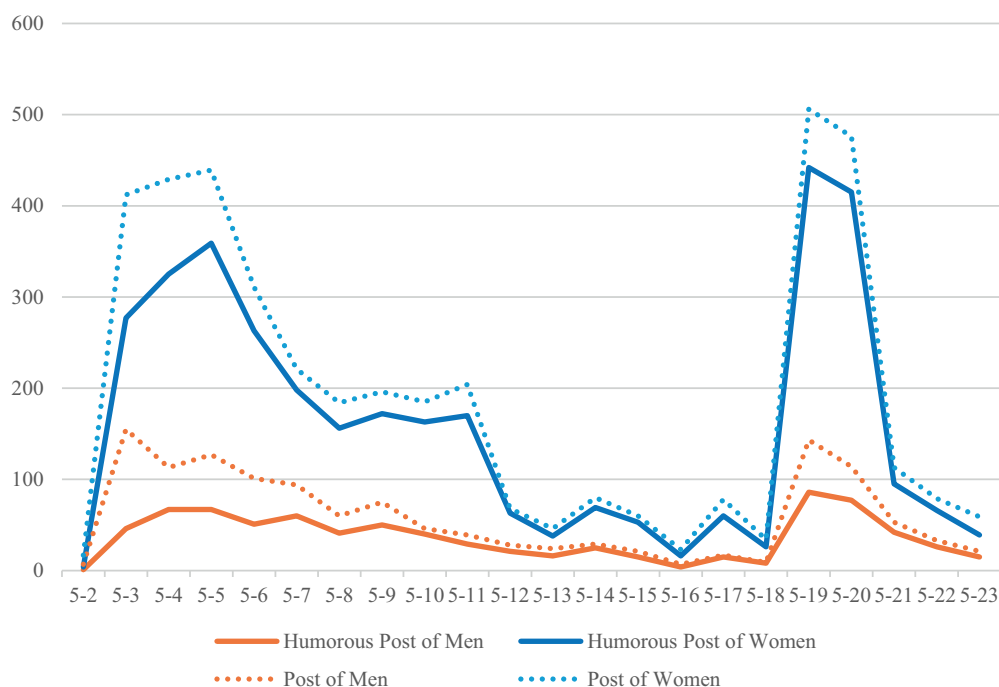


Figure 3. The trend of humor posts during the event.

these trends indicate that humor was a salient mode of participation—especially for women—during moments of narrative uncertainty and reversal. However, volume patterns alone cannot determine whether this humor was feminist rather than merely gendered, so the topic-modeling results below specify how humor functioned (e.g., critique, parody, boundary work) and what gendered power relations it targeted.

Topic analysis

To map the thematic structure of the online discourse, we applied topic modeling and identified 20 topics. The top five core keywords for each topic are reported in [Appendix 1](#). We then visualized topic proximity using pyLDAvis ([Figure 4](#)): topics positioned closer together exhibit more similar word distributions, indicating stronger semantic overlap. Based on these spatial relationships, the 20 topics were further organized into seven broader thematic clusters. These clusters provide the analytic scaffold for the qualitative interpretation that follows, where we examine both humorous and non-humorous posts to clarify when and how humor becomes feminist rather than merely gendered.

To capture gendered participation across themes, we calculated, for each topic, the proportion of humorous posts authored by female and male users. In the sections below, we read these distributions alongside representative textual examples to show how different gendered standpoints shaped—and at times weaponized—humor in the unfolding “Fat Cat” discourse.

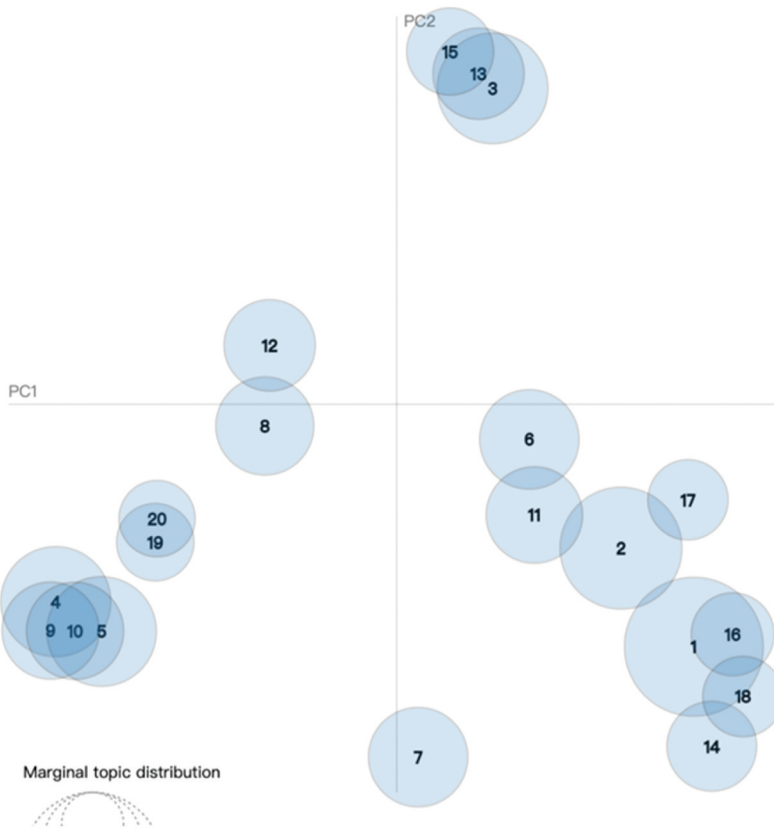


Figure 4. The results of Topic modeling visualized by the *pyLDAvis* Package.

From grief to grievance: the Manosphere's narrative

According to the initial narrative, which was largely built on selectively released chat logs, “Fat Cat” was framed as a devoted and affectionate boyfriend. His frugality stood in sharp contrast to the sizable transfers he allegedly made to his girlfriend, Tan Zhu, a detail that quickly struck a chord with many netizens. In the days that followed, mourning took a highly platform-specific form: people began placing online food deliveries (OFD) on the bridge where he jumped. This kind of digital mourning is not entirely new. It echoes long-standing funeral practices in China, such as offering a deceased person’s favorite foods (Candi K Cann 2017). OFD-based memorials also became more visible during COVID-19 lockdowns, when “sending food” felt more concrete—and, for some, more sincere—than purely symbolic online gestures (Deby Babis 2021; Angela Riechers 2013). As a repeatable act, it can also create a quick sense of belonging: even strangers can “join in” by doing the same thing, which helps produce a temporary collective identity (Xun Cao, Runxi Zeng and Richard Evans 2022).

In this early phase, feminist humor was not yet the main driver. Most of the humor came from male users. As shown in Table 2, male-authored humor was especially prominent in Topic 12 (48.9%) and Topic 8 (89.2%), which gives this cluster a distinctly male tone. At the same time, the overall humor proportion in the cluster remained low,

Table 2. The proportion of humorous posts in each Topic.

Cluster	Topic #	The Proportion of Humorous Posts		
		Female	Male	Different
1	8	79.2%	89.2%	−10.0%
1	12	47.7%	48.9%	−1.2%
2	2	62.4%	51.6%	10.8%
2	17	42.3%	17.2%	25.0%
3	1	100.0%	100.0%	/
3	16	95.6%	38.6%	56.9%
3	18	64.3%	58.7%	5.6%
4	6	97.7%	77.9%	19.8%
4	11	87.2%	63.4%	23.8%
4	14	97.3%	75.0%	22.3%
5	19	97.6%	85.0%	12.6%
5	20	95.2%	89.2%	5.9%
5	3	98.7%	40.8%	57.9%
5	7	89.2%	68.2%	21.0%
5	13	93.1%	54.5%	38.5%
6	15	88.8%	55.9%	32.9%
7	4	71.8%	53.9%	17.9%
7	5	80.1%	73.2%	6.9%
7	9	82.9%	68.9%	14.0%
7	10	100.0%	100.0%	/

suggesting a transitional moment: the OFD ritual was still framed as mourning, but it was already being pulled toward a gendered argument. *The “Witch Hunt” for a “Gold Digger” (Topic 12)*

Initially, Topic 12 was dominated by sympathy, and humor was limited among both men and women. As more financial details circulated, however, the discussion shifted. Once money became the focal point, some male users began labeling Tan Zhu a “gold digger,” and humor started to do narrative work. It redirected attention away from grief and toward punishment. One user wrote, *“It is fine for a gold digger to target rich people, but to prey on someone who only spends ten yuan on takeout . . . You truly deserve to die.”* In the Chinese manosphere, financial exchange in relationships is an especially sensitive trigger, so this line of talk spread quickly and hardened into a full-fledged “witch hunt” against Tan Zhu. *Anti-Misandry and Misogyny (Topic 8)*

The anger aimed at a perceived “gold digger” did not remain narrowly focused for long. It expanded into broader resentment toward feminism and women in general. In that sense, the “Fat Cat” story offered an almost ready-made archetype of a supposedly greedy and malicious woman positioned against contemporary feminist claims. For some male users, the incident became a convenient pretext to attack both “misandry” and feminism in one move. Within Topic 8, many posts used the commemoration of “Fat Cat” to criticize the expectation that men should bear greater financial responsibility in relationships. Humor was particularly effective here because it allowed users to mock rather than argue. One male user, for example, borrowed a phrase from the chat logs, *“Happy Valentines, and I want 9999 in next Valentines,”* and turned it into a slogan to ridicule women’s perceived materialism. In short, the OFD memorial initially functioned as a public expression of sympathy, and users of all genders participated. But because money, provision, and “male responsibility” are already fiercely debated gender issues in China, the ritual was quickly co-opted by manosphere discourse. It acquired gendered meanings and set the stage for the conflict that followed.

Desecration: redefining, gendering, and labeling the memorial ritual

While the early memorial ritual was not explicitly gendered, it did not remain “sacred” for long. A critical conversation about its legitimacy soon emerged, and feminist activism on Weibo helped push that shift. Female users increasingly used feminist humor to point out the gender politics and logical contradictions embedded in the ritual. Humor gave these critiques a sharper edge and a wider reach, helping them circulate beyond the initial circle of participants and gradually changing how the event was framed in public discussion. The topics in this cluster (1, 2, 6, 11, 14, 16, 17, and 18) capture this transition, showing a clear rise in female-authored humor, often in settings where comedy would normally seem out of place. *De-sacralization: Questioning the Commemoration (Topics 2, 17)*

In early May, discussion around the memorial shifted after several beverage shops near Chongqing’s Yangtze River Bridge reportedly substituted drink orders with plain water to reduce waste. When the practice surfaced online, it triggered backlash. Cha Bai Dao dismissed the employees involved and made a donation in “Fat Cat’s” name. The episode did more than spark brand controversy. It opened up broader doubts about the commemorative act itself and sharpened disagreement between male and female users. Two debates became especially visible. Topic 17 questioned authenticity and escalation, particularly after Tan Zhu publicly claimed she was being “slandered.” Some female users responded by arguing that the condemnation of both her and the associated brands had already crossed a line. Topic 2, by contrast, focused on whether the ritual had turned into a waste of public resources, reflected in keywords such as “wasting food” and “sanitation workers.” Notably, for a segment of female users, this was also the moment when the incident became readable through a gendered lens. They described the intense male response as a “witch hunt” and pushed back against derogatory labels such as “gold digger” (Topic 17). Humor remained relatively rare in these two topics, which sit at the low end of humorous proportion in the dataset, but they travelled through careful, reasonable-sounding reflection rather than punchline-driven virality. As these critiques spread, the ritual’s sacral aura and the idolization of “Fat Cat” weakened, and gender became a more explicit axis for interpreting what the memorial was doing and whom it was protecting. *Defamiliarization :Redefining the Ritual with Dark Humor (Topic 1,16)*

As the memorial ritual lost its sacral aura, it began to attract hostile labels. Humor, especially dark humor, accelerated this shift by making the ritual feel “strange” again, so that what had seemed self-evidently respectful could be re-read as excessive or even performative. In other words, defamiliarization works by breaking a familiar frame and forcing a second look, interrupting habitual sympathy and inviting re-evaluation (Alberto Godioli 2024, 128). In these discussions, female users, many of whom had recently been targets of online “witch hunts,” were noticeably more active than men, not necessarily because the jokes were already “about gender,” but because humor offered a low-cost way to contest the dominant tone of reverence.

One recurring question in Topic 16 was whether “Fat Cat,” as an ordinary person rather than a public figure, warranted such extensive mourning. While many male users continued to emphasize the tragedy, female users often punctured the solemn atmosphere through satire. Some suggested that the country should establish a “national day of mourning,” complete with “three days of nationwide leave” and “McDonald’s discounts,” a deliberately absurd proposal that exposed what they saw as the fan-like devotion

surrounding the ritual. This critique sharpened through a viral post that irreverently linked “Fat Cat” to other deceased figures revered by different online communities, including Gao Yan, an LGBTQ+ student who died by suicide; Zhong Ni, a controversial influencer; and the athlete Kobe Bryant. *“Monday, mourn Gao Yan; Tuesday, mourn Mo Cha; Wednesday, mourn Fat Cat; Thursday, mourn Zhong Ni; Friday, mourn Kobe Bryant. Saturday, watch the five of them compete in a resurrection match. Sunday, eat McDonald’s and drink Cha Bai Dao by the river.”* (Topic 1)

For readers unfamiliar with Chinese internet culture, the humor works by turning mourning into a weekly schedule, as if grief were a content calendar. It stitches together deaths associated with different online subcultures and moral universes, which makes the comparison deliberately unsettling. The phrase “resurrection match” borrows gaming language and imagines the dead as characters who can respawn, clashing sharply with the solemn register of commemoration. Ending with McDonald’s and Cha Bai Dao, two branded items tied to the ritual, further reduces moral outrage to consumption cues. The joke relies on disproportion, repetition, and genre-mixing, which is precisely why it functions as defamiliarization rather than simple ridicule.

By placing a sacred act of mourning into an unsettling comparative frame, the post did not simply mock grief; it disrupted the moral certainty of the ritual and encouraged users to ask what the commemoration was really doing (Godioli 2024). It also circulated widely, which helps explain why Topic 1 shows one of the higher humor proportions across genders. Rather than claiming that the post “changed outcomes,” we treat it as evidence of a discursive turn: mourning was no longer taken for granted as respectful, but became available for critique. At this stage, the humor was still not explicitly centered on gender. The immediate target was the memorial practice itself. Still, women’s use of satire mattered as an intervention in a space where grief rituals can be easily hijacked or attacked, including through “RIP trolling” dynamics (Babis 2021; Riechers 2013). By deconstructing a male-coded tragedy through dark humor, these posts opened a path for later arguments about whose pain is recognized, whose behavior is condemned, and how gendered moral judgments get attached to “public mourning.” *Gendering the Discourse: From Reflection to a War of Words* (Topic 6, 11, 14, 18)

Initially, the Fat Cat incident was not framed primarily through gender. The early narrative was tied to his role as a paid “booster” in the Honor of Kings community, so the first wave of memorial talk emerged from the Chinese esports scene, a space typically dominated by male voices. Keywords in Topic 11, including “Honor of Kings,” “boosting,” and “Meng Qi,”⁴ reflect that origin. As humorous content produced by women increased, it helped them find each other, share a common stance, and bring gender more explicitly into the discussion. In mid-May, female users began creating humor around Fat Cat’s gamer identity and co-opting esports symbols. They satirically dubbed him “China’s Top Meng Qi” and circulated an intentionally awkward collage based on the character’s appearance. Through repeated remixing and reposting, the image became a durable meme in photos, short videos, and skit-like posts.⁵ As narratives between male and female users polarized, Topic 6 increasingly turned into a war of words. Mockery and anger escalated, and some female users sarcastically compared Fat Cat to the poet Qu Yuan, who also died by drowning. Others joked that they would “steal the offerings” from the bridge to feed themselves. By this point, the memorial ritual was no longer treated as untouchable, it had become a site of gendered contestation. This shift is especially visible

in Topic 18. When the official Fat Cat Weibo community announced it was recruiting administrators, a female user posted a satirical “application” that stitched together the event’s key symbols. She wrote that she “... usually drinks milk tea, with Chai Bai Dao being her favorite; never eats KFC, only McDonald’s; never secretly consumes takeout; and uses a high-quality iPhone 15 Pro, genuinely wanting to do something for Fat Cat, politely applying.”

The post cleverly condensed the event’s symbols into one exaggerated persona, it worked as a recognition cue for feminists, prompted reposting, and was later deleted by the recruiter. Here, humor becomes explicitly activist. It challenges the romanticization of male “profound affection” and the moral pressure to keep the ritual beyond critique.

Feminist activism: digital feminist humor as a strategy of resistance

Digital feminist humor can function as a practical strategy for confronting misogyny, not only by entertaining but by exposing sexism through satire (Gallivan 1992). In the earlier phases of the “Fat Cat” discourse, women’s humor loosened the grip of the initial narrative by picking at its contradictions. As the memorial ritual itself became contested, women more deliberately used those logical faults to produce satire that was recognisably feminist rather than merely gendered. This shift coincided with a higher proportion of humorous posts and a widening gap between female and male humor production across several topics. What we can claim from the dataset is a discursive shift, not a direct causal “outcome.” Women’s humor repeatedly redirected attention from reverence to critique and kept alternative framings visible when the dominant tone privileged a male-centered story. *Labeling Male Insincerity* (Topic 19,20)

In Topics 19 and 20, critique moves from questioning the ritual in general to labeling a recognisable type of male hypocrisy through irony and contrast. A viral Weibo post constructs an exaggerated persona of a man who claims sympathy for Fat Cat while rehearsing misogyny and performing anxieties around money. “*I understand you, Mr. Handsome⁶ ... You say all pretty women are prostitutes but secretly look for ways to sell your dick ... You claim to sympathize with Fat Cat and want to punish so-called gold diggers, but you have to use credit services to afford a 15-yuan cup of milk tea ...*” (Topic 19)

At first glance, this can read as mocking “poverty.” However, economic precarity itself is not the target here. The humor works by puncturing a righteous pose that relies on misogynistic common sense about women’s sexuality and “materialism.” The consumer-credit detail matters because it exposes a contradiction: the speaker performs moral authority while revealing everyday vulnerability. In doing so, the post shows how blame is redirected onto women to sustain a gendered hierarchy of credibility and sympathy. We also acknowledge an ethical limit. Detached from its critique of misogyny, this tactic can slip into class contempt. We therefore treat it as feminist humor only insofar as it “punches up” at misogynistic scripts and the moral economy that authorizes them, rather than at economic hardship as such.

The post uses caricature to indict a moralising masculine persona common in manosphere discourse, one that performs righteousness while relying on misogynistic talk. It also worked as a recognition cue for women and travelled through sharing (Rentschler and Thrift 2015). Feminist humor is often discussed as sharp and in-group oriented (Shifman and Lemish 2011; Jenny Sunden and Susanna Paasonen

2020). Yet posts like this were sometimes shared by men as well, suggesting that certain satirical frames can travel beyond a single audience when the hypocrisy is widely recognisable. *Strategic Reversal: Mocking Male Susceptibility to Manipulation* (Topics 3,7,13,15)

On May 19, the official investigation reported that transfers between Tan Zhu and “Fat Cat” were mutual rather than one-sided (CCTV News 2024). This reversal weakened the story’s moral clarity and made the earlier devotion easier to question (Topic 3). Women used the report as a hinge for a new round of humor that recast the “pure love” narrative as naïveté, entitlement, or moral panic.

Some posts directly mocked male susceptibility to manipulation (Topics 7, 13). Others parodied near-religious adoration by borrowing the language of idol worship (Topic 15), a style often used to stereotype young women. One example mimics the cadence of a fan tribute. *“The World’s Top River-Jumping Warrior [Fat Cat]/Only at twenty-one, he holds dual luxury endorsements with [Cha Bai Dao and Wallace]/Pure Love Warrior/National Mengqi Player/McDonald’s Underworld Regional Promotion Ambassador/Such a great boy, love him is never a loss.”*⁷ (Topic 15)

By applying a genre used to ridicule “irrational fangirls” to a man celebrated in manosphere discourse, these posts perform a strategic reversal. They keep the memorial’s key symbols in view while turning the gaze back onto the men who framed themselves as moral judges. In this sense, the humor is feminist not because it simply targets men, but because it punches up at a gendered moral economy that grants men sympathy and authority while casting women as suspect. *Societal Reflection and the Legacy of the Discourse* (Topics 4,5,9,10) After dark humor spread, a noticeable shift occurred in how users talked about both the memorial ritual and the original story. Some male users began to pick up the critical framing that women had articulated earlier and started contributing their own jokes. Topics 4, 5, 9, and 10 still remained female-dominated, but male-authored humor increased, narrowing the gender gap. Rather than signalling agreement on “what really happened,” this convergence suggests that the ritual’s sacred status had become easier to question in public talk.

Two developments are especially clear in this cluster. First, users began using humor to ridicule what they saw as “trend-following” mourning in later incidents (Topics 4, 5), treating public commemoration as a routinized performance rather than an unquestionable moral duty. Second, some users turned their attention to the question of “who deserves to be mourned” and formed groups that resemble what researchers describe as “RIP trolls,” deploying mockery to challenge memorial practices they considered excessive or misplaced (Kimberly C Seigfried-Spellar and Shama S Chowdhury 2017). This behavior is ethically ambiguous, but it matters analytically because it points to a loosening of the cultural expectation that the dead should be insulated from critique (Topic 10).

The more lasting legacy, however, lies in the way this discourse generated a portable interpretive template for intimate relationships. When later cases emerged with reversed gender roles, such as the Hua Shaobei (male) and Jian Dan (female) episode, users referenced the “Fat Cat” event as a cautionary frame. They reused the motif of “ordering takeout” to flag emotional and economic exploitation in relationships, regardless of gender (Topic 9). What endures, then, is less a settled judgment about the case than an interpretive repertoire, a form of discursive shorthand through which users can name and contest performative grief, moral panics, and the gendered distribution of sympathy.

Discussion

The “Fat Cat” incident began as a story anchored in grief and gaming culture, but it gradually became a site where gendered moral judgments were contested in public. What this case helps clarify is not that humor “won” the debate, but how digital feminist humor can keep alternative framings in circulation under conditions where overt feminist speech is costly. In the Chinese platform environment, feminist organising often happens in fragmented, low-visibility ways, and humor can function as a practical connective tissue for recognition and alignment (Holly Lixian Hou 2015; L Hou 2020; Liao 2024). Here, jokes worked as recognition cues. They allowed women to identify one another, condense shared experiences into repeatable forms, and sustain collective attention even when the dominant tone privileged a male-centered narrative (Lawrence and Ringrose 2018; Jia Tan 2025).

Across the clusters, humor also functions as an infrastructure for re-framing through circulation and reuse. The same symbols that initially stabilized a male-centered story, the bridge, takeout, milk tea brands, are repeatedly recycled in later jokes as shorthand for exploitation, moral panic, and performative grief. This recycling matters because it shows how feminist humor can keep a counter-reading active even as the factual narrative shifts. Rather than relying on a single “correction” moment, humor produces a portable interpretive repertoire that travels across topics and can be re-applied to later cases. In this sense, the politics of humor lies in repetition and recontextualisation as much as in immediate persuasion. It also helps explain why some satirical frames were later taken up by male users, even when their initial function was to build feminist recognition and boundary work.

A second contribution of this case lies in the link between feminist humor and defamiliarization. Dark humor made the memorial ritual feel strange again, pulling it out of a “sacred” register and reopening it to evaluation. This discomfort is not merely transgressive for its own sake. It becomes politically productive when it exposes the taken-for-granted moral economy that grants men sympathy and authority while casting women as suspect. At the same time, not all gendered humor is feminist. The difference often lies in where the punch lands, whether it targets patriarchal norms and misogynistic discourse or simply reproduces gender essentialism. In this sense, humor here operates less as persuasion than as boundary work and frame maintenance, keeping feminist counter-readings legible when platform conditions make explicit critique costly. Finally, the later uptake of certain satirical frames by some male users suggests that feminist humor is not always confined to an in-group audience, even if its primary work remains the consolidation of feminist publics and the contestation of misogynistic common sense (Massanari 2019; Shifman and Lemish 2011; Sunden and Paasonen 2020).

Conclusion

The “Fat Cat” incident offers a revealing case for understanding digital feminist humor in a contested platform environment. Rather than claiming measurable causal effects, this paper shows how women used dark humor and memes to keep alternative framings in circulation when the dominant tone privileged a male-centered story. Humor worked as a practical intervention. It enabled recognition and

solidarity, and it defamiliarized a memorial ritual that had been treated as morally untouchable.

More broadly, the gendering of this memorial shows how mourning can become a resource for struggle, and how narratives of “pure love” and “sacrifice” can be translated into gendered moral judgments that distribute sympathy unevenly. Not all gendered humor is feminist, and the key analytic question is where the punch lands, whether it targets patriarchal norms and misogynistic discourse or slides into gender essentialism. Future research can compare similar episodes across platforms and contexts and, through reception-focused methods such as interviews or surveys, clarify what can and cannot be inferred from discursive shifts in platform data alone.

Notes

1. Chinese fast food brand
2. Chinese bubble tea brand
3. Chinese bubble tea brand
4. A character Fat Cat often played
5. The humor comes from exaggerated “top player” praise applied to a tragedy, and from the deliberate crudeness of the collage, which punctures the tone of reverence.
6. “Mr. Handsome” translates *shuai ge*, a casual address often used sarcastically online. The humor builds by stacking contradictions until the moral pose collapses.
7. It stacks fandom-style titles but pairs them with low-end takeaway brands. The mismatch makes the devotion look performative and absurd.

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Notes on contributors

Peizhi Huang is a postdoctoral fellow in the School of Journalism and Communication at Tsinghua University. Her research lies at the intersection of gender studies, cultural studies, and sexuality studies, with a focus on gender identity, sexual roles, and contemporary Chinese popular culture. Her work has been published in *Sexualities*. She has presented at the International Communication Association (ICA) and the International Association for Media and Communication Research (IAMCR), and received a Best Paper Award at the AEJMC LGBTQ panel.

Hongcheng Lu is a PhD student in the School of Journalism and Communication at Tsinghua University, specializing in gender studies, digital culture, and media economics. His research examines how gender identities and representations are shaped and reshaped in digital spaces. His work has been presented at multiple international conferences, such as the International Communication Association (ICA), contributing to ongoing discussions on gender representation in the digital era.

ORCID

Peizhi Huang  <http://orcid.org/0009-0004-9154-0092>

Hongcheng Lu  <http://orcid.org/0009-0006-5757-0946>

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Appendix. Result of topic modeling and top 5 words for each topic

Topic #	Top 5 Words	Translation
1	哭坟 高彦 玫瑰 草莓 仲尼	Crying at Grave, Gao Yan (Person), Rose, Strawberry, Zhong Ni (Person)
2	外卖 胖猫姐姐 浪费粮食 视频 网友	Online food deliveries, Fat Cat's Sister (Person), Wasting Food, Video, Netizens
3	警方通报 情况 外卖 奶茶 纯爱战神	Police Report, Situation, Online food deliveries, Milk Tea, Pure Love Warrior
4	事件 外卖 空包 小时 品牌	Incident, Online food deliveries, Empty Package, Hour, Brand
5	麦当劳 套餐 谭竹 十块钱 产品	McDonald's (Brand), Set Meal, Tan Zhu (Person), Ten RMB, Product
6	外卖 全国 祭品 冷暴力 屈原	Online food deliveries, Nationwide, Offering, Cold Violence, Qu Yuan (Person)
7	麦当劳 名单 外卖 晚安 姐妹	McDonald's (Brand), List, Takeout, Good Night, Sister
8	人家 外卖 神经 结果 孩子	People, Online food deliveries, Jerk, Result, Child
9	外卖 热度 鲜花 花少北 事发地	Online food deliveries, Popularity, Flowers, Hua Shaobei (Person), Incident Location
10	纪念 建议 免费 麦当劳 国家	Memorial, Suggestion, Free, McDonald's (Brand), Country
11	名字 王者荣耀 游戏 代练 跳河	Name, Honor of Kings (Game), Game, Boosting, Jumping into River
12	外卖 谭竹 十块钱 事件 女友	Online food deliveries, Tan Zhu (Person), Ten Yuan, Incident, Girlfriend
13	捞女 奶茶 女友 兄弟 现实	Female Gold Digger (Net Slang), Milk Tea, Girlfriend, Brother, Reality
14	华莱士 麦当劳 支持 评论 捞男	Wallace (Brand), McDonald's (Brand), Support, Comment, Male Gold Digger (Net slang)
15	纯爱战神 男孩 梦奇 麦当劳 国服	Pure Love Warrior, Boy, Mengqi (Game Character), McDonald's (Brand), Rank in China (Game)
16	华莱士 网友 蜜雪冰城 热搜 空包	Wallace (Brand), Netizens, Mixue Bingcheng (Brand), Hot Search, Empty Package
17	事件 女主 舆论 网暴 生活	Incident, Female Lead, Public Opinion, Cyberbullying, Life
18	茶百道 奶茶 麦当劳 肯德基 外卖	Cha Bai Dao (Brand), Milk Tea, McDonald's (Brand), KFC (Brand), Takeout
19	世界 工作 奶茶 捞女 美女	World, Work, Milk Tea, Gold Digger (Net Slang), Beauty
20	共情 奶茶 医院 女孩 游戏	Empathy, Milk Tea, Hospital, Girl, Game